leverage to expand Sino–Iranian cooperation. “The geopolitical value of Iran is immense for any power that seeks an ambitious role in West Asia.” Another article in *The Hindu* quoted an Iranian trade representative to this effect: “Westerners visiting the capital [Tehran] often wonder how we managed to pull off such ambitious projects during the heaviest sanction regime in history. Well we did it with the help from our Chinese friends.”[18] The point: China was making hay with Iran.

In May 2016, four months after Xi’s visit to Tehran, Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi arrived in the same city to discuss with Iran’s leaders “the full range of our bilateral engagement.” Modi’s visit to Tehran was the first by an Indian Prime Minister since Vajpayee’s 2001 visit. “We exchanged views on the emerging regional situation and global issues of common concern,” Modi told the media.[19] Modi, like Vajpayee, represented the BJP and was determined to set Indian diplomacy on a more proactive course. Almost certainly Modi sought assurances that Tehran would not allow its expanding partnership with China to injure India’s security. During his Tehran visit, Modi expressed confidence about India’s relation with Iran in this way: “The agenda and scope of our partnership is truly substantial. The outcomes and agreements signed today open a new chapter in our strategic partnership.” “Deeper connectivity, including railways” was one aspect of the “new chapter in our [India–Iran] strategic partnership,” Modi said.

A key element of expanded India–Iran cooperation agreed to during Modi’s visit was an agreement to jointly develop Chabahar port. Originally agreed to during the Vajpayee–Khatami exchanges in 2001–2003, then suspended as US–Iran relations deteriorated following revelations of Iran’s previously clandestine nuclear programme and the international sanctions that followed, the Chabahar project was revived following the JCPOA. Under the May 2016 India–Iran agreement, India was to provide US$500 million for